

Narrow & Research



Class 4 · Wednesday, September 9, 2026

Narrow to Two

Let's Go Around the Room

- Five businesses narrowed down to your final two
- What you found in your quick-scan, and your pick of two
- Keep it tight: 2 to 3 minutes each
- Duplicate businesses get sorted live once everyone's shared
- Then we break before the deep-dive lecture

Deep-Dive Research

The Framework

Three pillars, nine questions. This is the research that everything else gets built on.

Brand Core

OUR WHY

- Purpose
- Vision
- Values

Brand Positioning

OUR WHAT & HOW

- Customers
- Competitors
- Difference

Brand Persona

OUR WHO

- Personality
- Brand Voice
- Perceptions

What Is Brand Purpose?

- Not necessarily about saving the world
- ...but it can be
- Purpose is the “why” beyond revenue and profit
- We all need a reason beyond money: belief and meaning

Real Example: Brand Core, Purpose

Brand Core: Purpose

To bring clarity and peace of mind to
homeowners through trusted guidance
and quality home improvements.

Easehouse | Strategy Structure Playbook

5

Real KURTZ client work — Easehouse, Brand Core: Purpose

What Is Brand Vision?

- Vision is the future brand
- Vision must be driven by brand leaders
- A 5 to 15 year time horizon
- Intimidating, but achievable

Real Example: Brand Core, Vision

Brand Core: Vision

What we strive for:

To lead the industry in innovation, trust,
and reliability by scaling what we do
best without losing who we are.

Nova | Strategy Structure Playbook

6

Real KURTZ client work — Nova, Brand Core: Vision

What Are Brand Values?

- A belief of the leadership about how business should be done
- Expressed values show up in experiences and reputation
- Without action, they're pointless
- Inauthentic actions betray values and lose customers

Real Example: Brand Core, Values

Brand Core: Values

The beliefs, philosophies, and principles that drive our business:

We Put People First

Great results start with respect and genuine care for our team, our clients, and everyone we work with.

We Deliver On Our Promises

Reliability and accountability build long-term relationships and peace of mind.

We Pursue Excellence

Our clients deserve work we're proud of, and raising the bar drives our industry forward.

We Do The Right Thing

Integrity is the foundation for trust, and doing what's right sets us apart.

Forefront | Strategy Structure Playbook

7

Real KURTZ client work — ForeFront, Brand Core: Values

CORPID · ART 482 · CLASS 4 · FALL 2026

CORPID.KURTZ.CC

Who Are Our Customers?

- Successful brands have a deep understanding of their customer
- Use demographics and psychographics to build an avatar
- What is the pain they're in?
- What is the pleasurable outcome they desire?
- Understanding the journey leads to clear positioning and messaging

Real Example: Brand Positioning, Customers

Brand Positioning: Customers

Customer Avatar #1 – Profile:



Purchasing Manager

Mike

Age:
54

Sex:
Male

Location:
Ohio

Education:
Bachelor's degree

Household income:
\$165k

Groups:
Golf league, Hunting club

About Me:

I'm someone who enjoys family time, golf, and relaxing out on the water, but during the week my focus is on keeping production running smoothly at work. We build parts that power everything from homes to heavy industry, and there's always pressure to keep things moving. I take pride in solving problems, yet I often find myself dealing with late deliveries, poor communication, and materials that aren't available when I need them. It's frustrating and stressful, and at times it feels like no matter how hard I work, the pressure never lets up. What I really want is to get orders off my desk quickly, know the materials will arrive on time, and trust that I won't have to chase down issues. When things go right, I can enjoy the satisfaction of a job well done, feel confident in front of my boss, and spend my evenings stress-free with my family. Maybe even get recognized for the effort I put into a role that too often goes unnoticed.

Likes

✓ Caterpillar

✓ Ford

✓ Cabela's

✓ The Home Depot

Dislikes

✗ Wish

✗ Comcast

✗ Facebook

✗ Tesla

Comet Metals | Strategy Structure Playbook

10

Real KURTZ client work — CometMetals, Brand Positioning: Customer Avatar

CORPID · ART 482 · CLASS 4 · FALL 2026

CORPID.KURTZ.CC

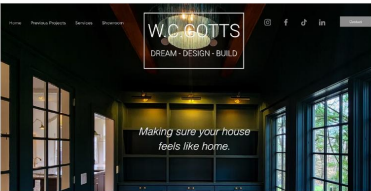
Who Are Our Competitors?

- Competitive research doesn't look for ways to replicate
- Knowing the market gives us insight and perspective
- Understanding strengths and weaknesses reveals gaps in the marketplace

Real Example: Brand Positioning, Competitors

Brand Positioning: Competitors

The competitive landscape (page 1 of 2):



Realtor / Investor / Contractor Combos

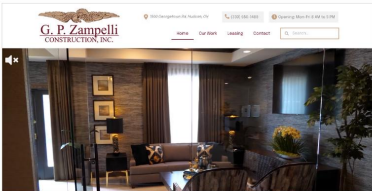
W. G. Gotts • Aikens • Renegade Roofing

Strengths

- High-end design and work
- Large crews and capacity
- Strong local reputation
- Offers full-scale projects

Weaknesses

- Expensive and overbooked
- Slow turnaround times
- Less focused on sellers
- Not ideal for small jobs



Builders / Remodelers / Design Companies

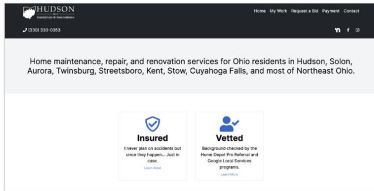
Zampelli • Slabaugh • Liberty Home Contractors

Strengths

- Established brands
- Full remodel and design services
- High-quality workmanship
- Capable of large projects

Weaknesses

- Too large for small jobs
- High prices and overhead
- Long lead times
- Not focused on punch lists



Solo Operators / Handymen

Hudson Handyman • Winnen Handyman • Josh Fritz

Strengths

- Affordable and accessible
- Locally known via referrals
- Handles basic repair tasks
- Flexible with small jobs

Weaknesses

- Poor communication habits
- Inconsistent workmanship
- Limited capabilities
- Unreliable scheduling

Real KURTZ client work — Easehouse, Brand Positioning: Competitors

What Is Our Difference?

- Customers need a reason
- They don't "just get it"
- Customers want an easy decision
- We can't be everything to everyone
- What is the one thing we want to be remembered for?

Real Example: Brand Positioning, Difference

Brand Positioning: Difference

Why we are unique:

We earn trust through personal service,
creative problem-solving, and consistency
in an industry filled with tight deadlines,
unpredictable supply chains, and vendors
that treat you like a number.

Nova | Strategy Structure Playbook

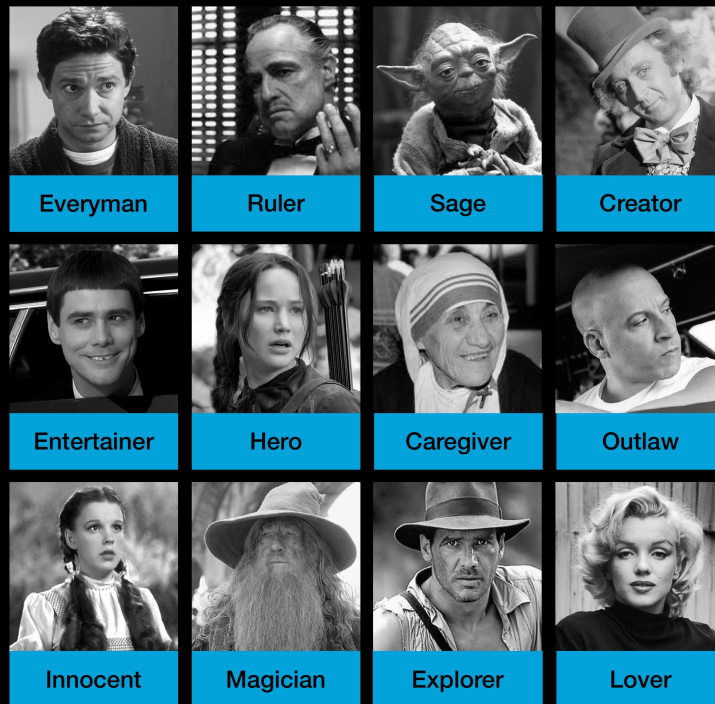
20

Real KURTZ client work — Nova, Brand Positioning: Difference

What Is Brand Personality?

- Most brands are robotic. We're bringing ours to life
- A human personality is easier to believe and trust
- What attributes best represent our role?
- We build it from the 12 brand archetypes, a Jungian framework

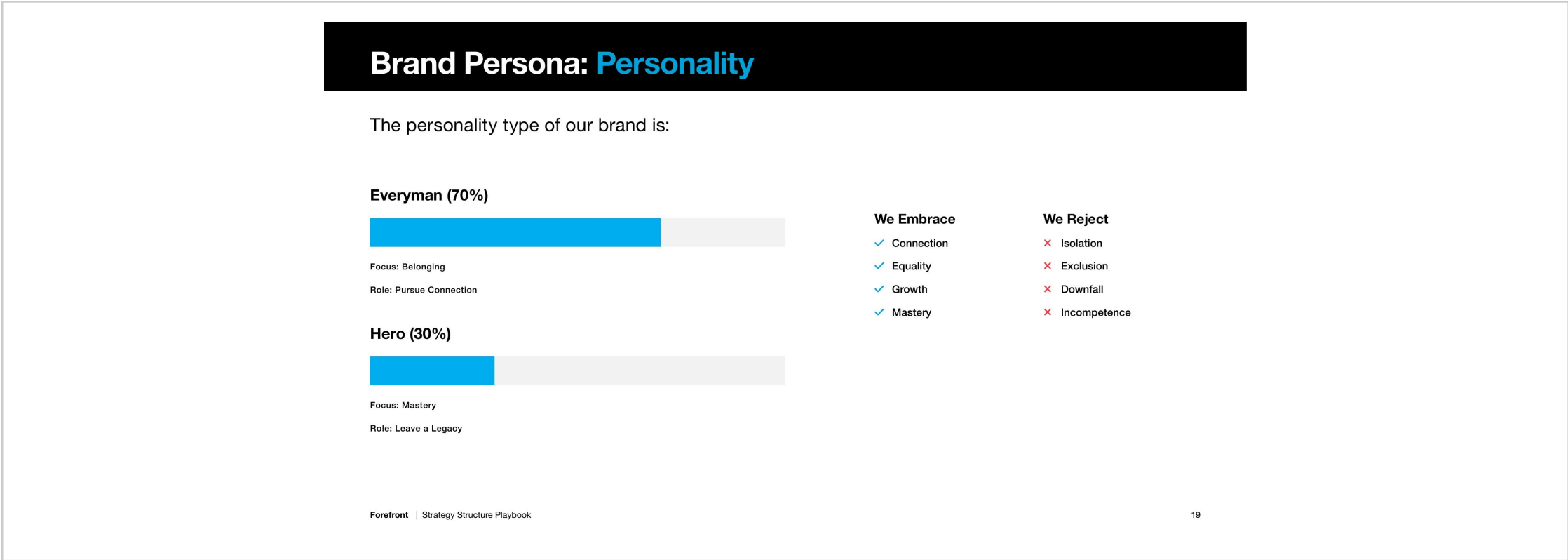
Brand Personality as Archetypes



- Carl Jung identified twelve universally recognizable character types in 1919
- In the late 1990s brand communication started to become “two ways”
- Brands needed to feel like they had a “personality” to communicate
- Utilizing archetypes allows brands to resonate on a deep emotional level
- Identify the archetype that best aligns with corporate culture, products/services, and customer expectations
- Choose two to be familiar yet unique

From KURTZ's brand strategy teaching materials — the 12 Jungian archetypes

Real Example: Brand Persona, Personality

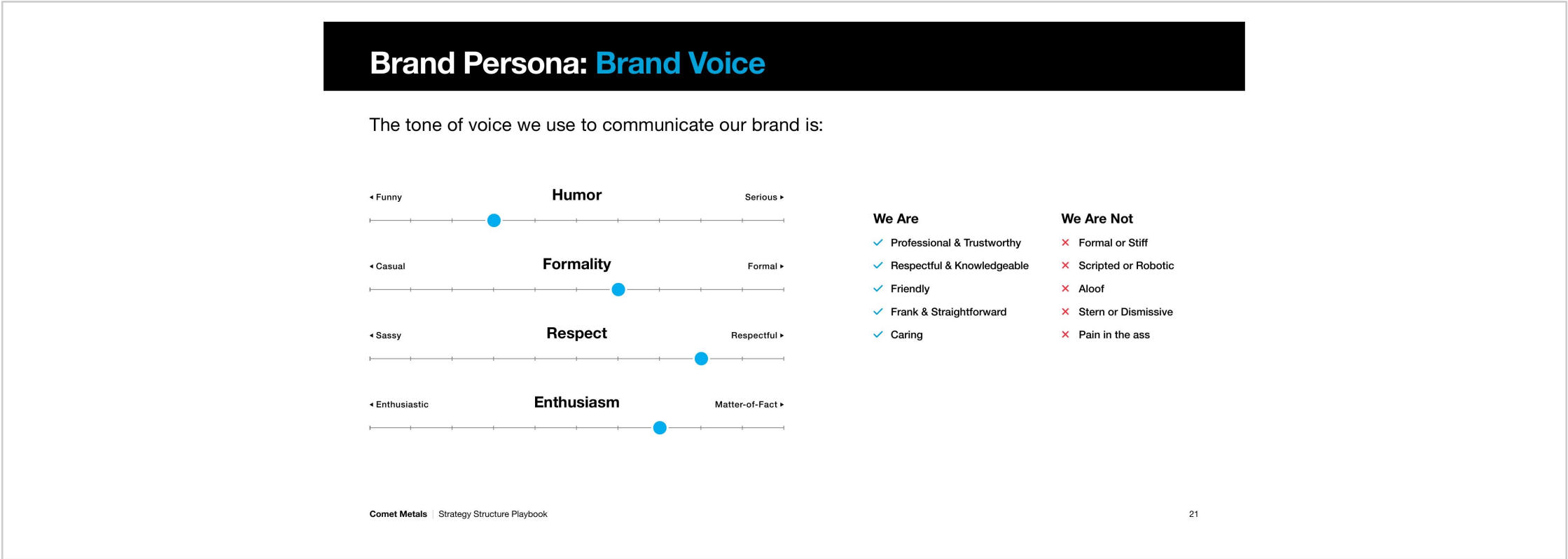


Real KURTZ client work — ForeFront, Brand Persona: Personality

What Is Our Brand Voice?

- How do we sound to others?
- It's not just WHAT you say, but HOW you say it
- What style of language best represents our brand?

Real Example: Brand Persona, Voice



Real KURTZ client work — CometMetals, Brand Persona: Voice. We're not building this out tonight, but it's part of every full brand strategy engagement.

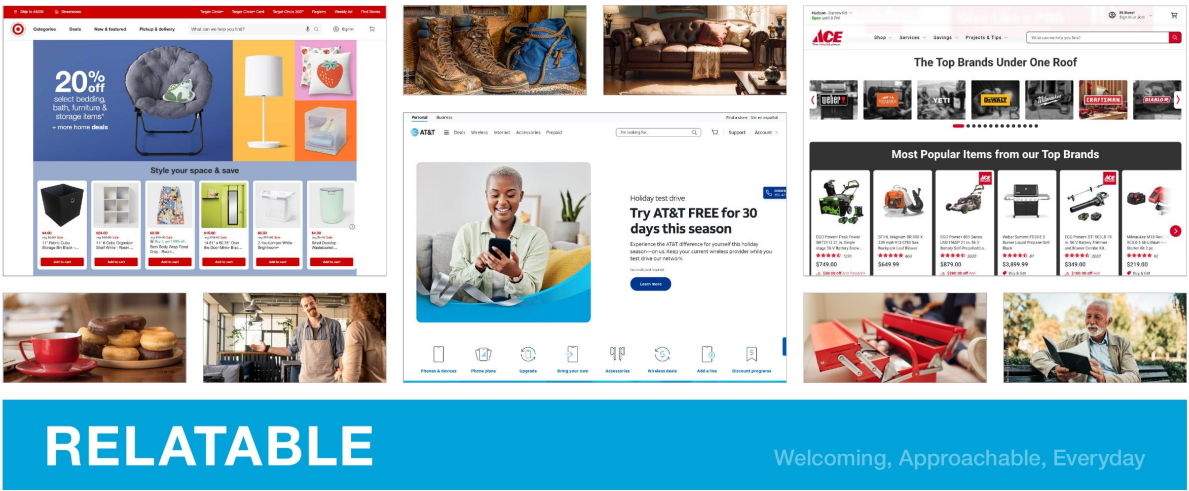
What Are Our Brand Perceptions?

- When our ideal customer sees our brand, what do we want them to think?
- Who we are, and who we are not
- What do people believe we represent?
- This is where strategy starts becoming visual vocabulary

Real Example: Brand Persona, Perceptions

Brand Persona: Perceptions

Our ideal customer should perceive our brand as (page 1 of 4):



Easehouse | Strategy Structure Playbook

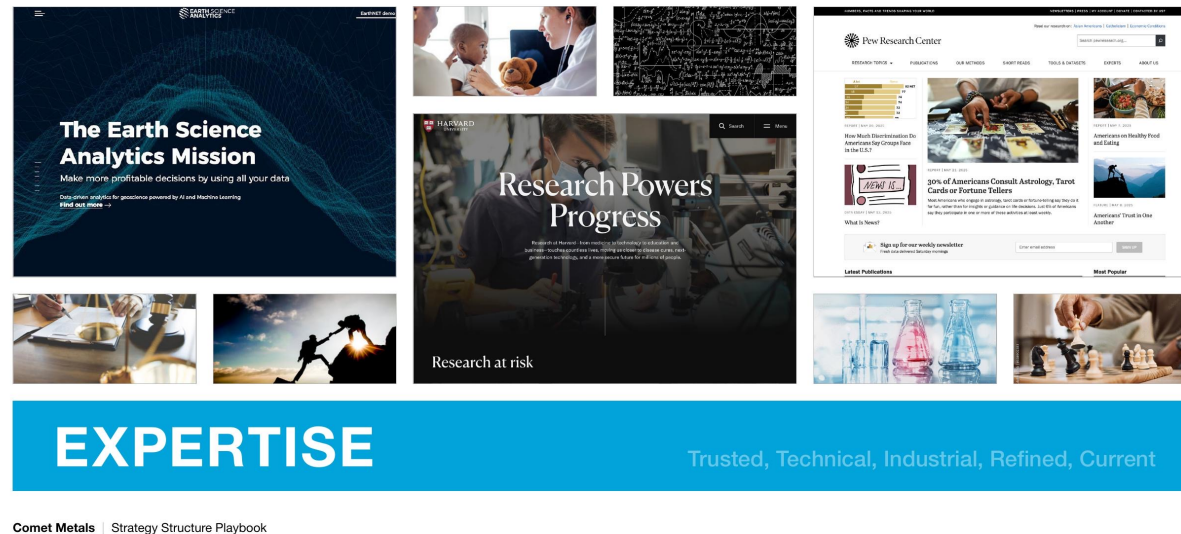
21

Real KURTZ client work — Easehouse, Brand Persona: Perceptions, “Relatable”

Real Example: Brand Persona, Perceptions

Brand Persona: Perceptions

Our ideal customer should perceive our brand as (page 3 of 4):



Real KURTZ client work — CometMetals, Brand Persona: Perceptions, "Expertise"

What We Covered Tonight

Nine questions. This is the research your deep-dive assignment needs to answer.

Brand Core

OUR WHY

- Purpose
- Vision
- Values

Brand Positioning

OUR WHAT & HOW

- Customers
- Competitors
- Difference

Brand Persona

OUR WHO

- Personality
- Brand Voice
- Perceptions

Questions?

Bring solid progress on both finalists, Monday is a studio session, we'll work through it together.